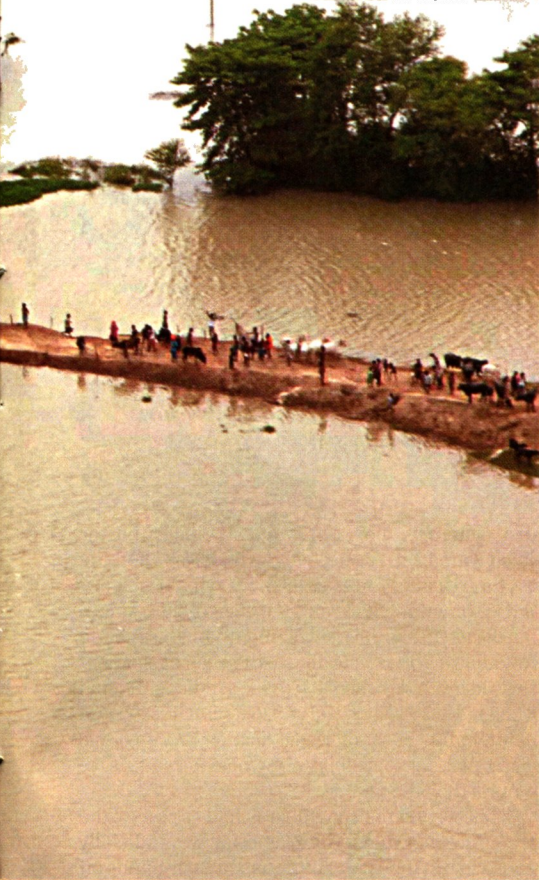


MAROONED: An aerial view of a flood-affected area of Saharsa in north Bihar



Photographs by KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

ment could be the result of lack of maintenance. The argument gains credence because the river had failed to cause as much damage to Bihar villages during the previous seven times when it had breached the barrage near Kusaha in Nepal.

Incidentally, the Kosi carries with its waters tonnes of silt every year, which it keeps depositing along its course from the plains of Nepal to Kursela in Bihar where it joins the mighty Ganga. The current breach is also said to have resulted due to heavy siltation that often forces the river to look for a new path. The heavy silt deposits and the land tilt are believed to have guided the river eastward this time and as a result, the river, which had shifted its course from east to west by over 120 km during the last 250 years, now suddenly has a new path. A weak embankment gave way to the turbulent water and then as if possessing the instinct of a wild beast, the river trampled everything that came in its way.

The breach was also caused by the heavy siltation before the Bhimnagar barrage which, unlike previous times, was not even perfunctorily desilted before the onset of the monsoon this year. Locals in Supaul said the engineers and the water resources officials had enough time to plug the breach when it was first discovered in the first week of August. But two weeks were allowed to lapse before the river struck with all its fury.

The Kosi river is now travelling into an area where people had not experienced floods and, therefore had no fear of the disaster for at least three decades. Today, they stand trapped between the old and the new streams of the river. The 400-metre breach that was officially detected on August 18 has now widened to almost three kilometre and is expanding further. And since then, the river that has earned the sobriquet the "Sorrow of Bihar" is living up to its notoriety.

Sweeping through the districts of Supaul, Madhepura, Araria, Saharsa, Khagaria—and now threatening to engulf parts of Katihar and Purnia—the Kosi fury has already spelt death and destruction. At present, the level of water discharged from the Kosi is 1.44 lakh cusec. Worse still, since the river is traditionally known to swell to a peak between the months of October and November—when the volume of water discharged increases five times—the destruction is likely to be much worse.

The problems in the case of Madhepura and Supaul—which stand the risk of getting wiped off the map—are most alarming. Sample this: over 30 inmates of Virpur subdivisional jail have gone missing after over five-feet high water column submerged the prison premises on August 24.

calamity besides famine. But this is different, because the state now has to evacuate over 12-15 lakh people, unprecedented for its sheer magnitude.

The shifting of the Kosi may have been referred to as a sudden and shocking happening by Bihar Government officials. But those in the know say this was waiting to happen. The river is known to have started building pressure on the embankment immediately after it was jacketed in the 1950s, though it failed to make an immediate impact. The guard was strong but it surely started eroding the corners in the absence of proper repair. Besides, experts believe the embankment checked the flow of water but not siltation and that made the difference in terms of shifting the course of the river. Officials concede that the current breaching of the embank-

The river is known to swell to peak between October and November and unless the Government takes immediate measures, a catastrophe could be waiting to happen.